RUNBOOK

An airline just banned AI agents from booking

A CEO publicly said bots can't buy tickets on behalf of customers

- Two separate threads on this blew up in 24 hours
- One thread passed 682 comments
- The debate isn't really about airlines

WHAT HAPPENED

The company drew a hard line on agent access

Not a technical block. A business decision

- Agents booking for users skip the normal sales funnel
- That funnel is where pricing and upsells happen
- The company wants the direct customer relationship

WHY IT MATTERS

Agent autonomy threatens three things businesses protect

This is the real pattern behind the backlash

- Pricing control: agents can compare and arbitrage instantly
- Customer data: the business loses the direct touchpoint
- Liability: who's responsible when an agent books wrong?

THE MECHANISM

Agents remove the friction businesses rely on

Friction isn't always a bug. Sometimes it's the business model

- Upsells happen in the gaps between steps
- Loyalty programs depend on direct repeat visits
- Dynamic pricing works better without comparison bots

THE OTHER SIDE

Agents aren't the enemy, bad guardrails are

Most of this gets fixed with design, not bans

- Rate limits and identity verification solve a lot of this
- Agents can disclose themselves instead of impersonating users
- APIs built for agents avoid the scraping arms race

LESSON

This is a preview of every industry with a funnel

Travel, insurance, retail, SaaS pricing pages, all exposed

- Any business with hidden pricing logic feels this first
- Expect more public bans before more public APIs
- The winners will build agent access on their own terms

PRACTICAL TAKEAWAY

If you're building agents, plan for pushback

What to actually do about this right now

- Design agents that identify themselves, not spoof humans
- Build human approval steps for anything with a price
- Expect some platforms to block you, have a fallback flow

CTA

What's your take on agents acting on your behalf?

I build these systems with guardrails, not just autonomy

- Curious where you'd draw the line on agent access
- Send me a workflow you'd want an agent to handle

Lark AI Agency | Paul Charles